subjects will have seen this frequent reaffirmation as a sermon in which the foundational message works as a leitmotif to underscore its significance.

The sermonizing monarch returns to proto-secularism in his twelfth edict, which has been generally seen as the supreme proclamation of tolerance for all religious and philosophical sects.[38] Its core feature is the belief that at the root of dhamma is a public culture in which every sect honours every other (they 'should learn and respect one another's Dharma'). And how is this to be practised?

> . . . restraint in regard to speech, (which means) that there should be no extolment of one's own sect or disparagement of other sects on inappropriate occasions and that it should be moderate in every case even on appropriate occasions.
>
> On the contrary, other sects should be duly honoured in every way (on all occasions).
>
> If (a person) acted in this way, (he) not only promotes his own sect, but also benefits other sects.
>
> But if (a person) acts otherwise, (he) not only injures his own sect but also harms other sects.
>
> Truly, if (a person) extols his own sect and disparages other sects with a view to glorifying his own sect owing merely to his attachment (to it, he) injures his own sect very severely by acting in that way.
>
> Therefore concord is commendable.[39]

The tolerance defined here is not a passive virtue of cordial disregard of the Other but rather a positive effort at a concord recognized as mutually beneficial. This being an important priority, the king said he bestowed 'men of all religious communities with gifts and with honours of various kinds, ascetics or householders.' Such gifting and honouring were not done for themselves but to ensure the growth of dhamma among them which, as he put it, required amiable and respectful forms of public interaction among them.

This proclamation of a social philosophy and accompanying political programme at Erragudi and elsewhere is likely to have reassured local populations that the emperor's Buddhism was not in the end intrusive. His articulation of moral zeal bordering on authoritarianism in relation to